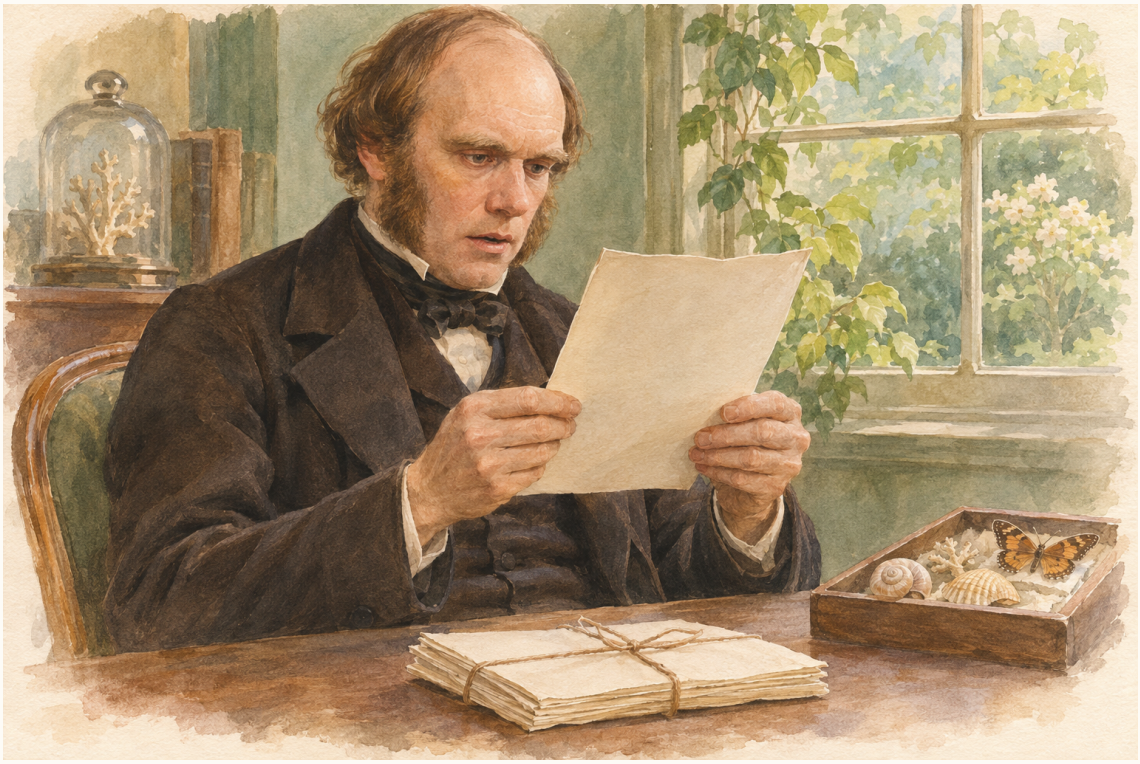
一封信惊醒了达尔文

The Letter That Startled Darwin



华莱士的来信为何让达尔文不安？

英文原文

Charles Darwin **disembarked** from HMS Beagle in October 1836. In September 1838 he began **formulating** the **principle** of natural **selection**: individuals better **adapted to** their **surroundings** survive and **pass on** their **hereditary traits**. By 1844 he had **composed** a 230-page **manuscript**, yet kept it **unpublished**, **cautiously amassing** evidence.

In February 1858, two decades after Darwin's first insight, Alfred Russel Wallace, a **naturalist afflicted by** fever in the Malay Archipelago, **independently conceived** the same idea. His **concise** essay reached Darwin on 18 June 1858. Its argument **paralleled** Darwin's own almost **precisely**; he told Charles Lyell he had never seen a more **remarkable coincidence**. His claim to **priority** seemed **threatened**.

Lyell and the **botanist** Joseph Hooker **arranged for** both papers to be read **simultaneously** at the Linnean Society, a scientific **institution** in London, on 1 July 1858. Neither author attended the **proceedings**. Wallace was abroad, and Darwin was **grieving**: **scarlet** fever had killed his **infant** son on 28 June. The **compromise**, struck without Wallace, may have kept **rivalry** over **precedence** at bay.

The papers' **publication** on 20 August 1858 met a **muted reception**. In May 1859 the Society's president **remarked** in his **yearly** address that the year had been **barren of revolutionary** discoveries. The **sensation** came on 24 November 1859 with Darwin's **treatise**, **On the Origin of Species**: booksellers had **subscribed for** every copy of its first **impression**, 1,250 in all.

Wallace had **readily signified** his **acceptance** in October 1858, **assuring** Hooker in a **cordial** letter of his **satisfaction** with the **arrangement**. In 1889 he published a **lengthy exposition** of the idea and **entitled** it Darwinism. Wallace never **named** the theory **after** himself.

中文译文

1836年10月，查尔斯·达尔文从小猎犬号上登岸。1838年9月，他开始构想并明确表述自然选择的原理：对周围环境适应得更好的个体存活下来，并将传递他们自身遗传的性状（给后代）。到1844年，他已撰写了一份230页的手稿，却一直未予发表，谨慎地积累着证据。

1858年2月，达尔文最初的洞察出现后的二十年，博物学家阿尔弗雷德·拉塞尔·华莱士在马来群岛饱受热病的折磨，独自一人构想出了同一个想法。华莱士这篇简明的文章于1858年6月18日到达了达尔文的手里。文中的论证与达尔文自己的几乎完全一样；达尔文告诉查尔斯·莱尔，自己从未见过比这更惊人的巧合。他对优先权的主张似乎受到了威胁。

莱尔和植物学家约瑟夫·胡克安排这两篇论文，于1858年7月1日在伦敦的科学机构林奈学会上被同时宣读。两位作者都没有出席这场会议。华莱士身在海外，达尔文则处于哀痛之中：猩红热在6月28日夺去了他幼子的生命。这一折中办法在华莱士未参与的情况下达成，或许避免了围绕先后次序的竞争。

这些论文于1858年8月20日的发表，遭遇了一个很不热烈的反响。1859年5月，学会会长在年度致辞中评论说，这一年一直毫无革命性的发现。这场轰动于1859年11月24日随着达尔文的专著《物种起源》到来：书商们已订购了该书首次印刷的每一册，总计1,250册。

华莱士早已欣然表明了接受的态度，那是在1858年10月；他在一封亲切的信中向胡克保证，自己对这一安排感到满意。1889年，他出版了一部长篇的阐述解释这一思想，并将其命名为《达尔文主义》。华莱士从未用自己的名字为这一理论命名。

词汇与表达

disembarked v.
登岸

formulating v.
构想并明确表述
he began formulating the principle of

principle n.
原理
he began formulating the principle of

selection n.
选择

adapted to v.
对……适应
individuals better adapted to their

surroundings n.
周围环境

pass on v.
传递

hereditary adj.
遗传的
and pass on their hereditary traits.

traits n.
性状
and pass on their hereditary traits.

composed v.
撰写了

manuscript n.
手稿
he had composed a 230-page manuscript,

unpublished adj.
未予发表

cautiously adv.
谨慎地

amassing v.
积累着
it unpublished, cautiously amassing

naturalist n.
博物学家

afflicted by v.
饱受……的折磨
a naturalist afflicted by fever in the

independently adv.
独自一人
independently conceived the same idea.

conceived v.
构想出
independently conceived the same idea.

concise adj.
简明的
His concise essay reached Darwin on 18

paralleled v.
与……一样

precisely adv.
完全

remarkable adj.
惊人的

coincidence n.
巧合
seen a more remarkable coincidence.

priority n.
优先权
claim to priority seemed threatened.

threatened v.
受到了威胁

botanist n.
植物学家

arranged for v.
安排

simultaneously adv.
同时
to be read simultaneously at the

词汇与表达（续）

institution n.
机构

proceedings n.
会议

grieving v.
哀痛

scarlet adj.
猩红

infant adj.
幼子

compromise n.
折中办法
compromise, struck without Wallace,

rivalry n.
竞争
may have kept rivalry over precedence

precedence n.
先后次序
may have kept rivalry over precedence

publication n.
发表

muted adj.
很不热烈的
20 August 1858 met a muted reception.

reception n.
反响
20 August 1858 met a muted reception.

remarked v.
评论

yearly adj.
年度

barren of adj.
毫无

revolutionary adj.
革命性的

sensation n.
轰动

On the Origin of Species n.
《物种起源》

treatise n.
专著

subscribed for v.
订购了

impression n.
次印刷

readily adv.
欣然

signified v.
表明了

acceptance n.
接受

assuring v.
向……保证

cordial adj.
亲切的
a cordial letter of his satisfaction

satisfaction n.
满意

arrangement n.
安排

lengthy adj.
长篇的

exposition n.
阐述
a lengthy exposition of the idea and

entitled v.
将……命名为
exposition of the idea and entitled it

named after v.
用……为……命名

文章简述

- 酝酿：达尔文1838年构想自然选择：更适应环境的生物较容易存活，并把自身特征传给后代。1844年他已写成230页手稿，仍继续搜集证据，没有发表。
- 来信：华莱士独立想出同一原理，1858年寄来的文章几乎与达尔文一致，令达尔文担心自己的首创地位。
- 折中：莱尔、胡克安排两人成果于1858年7月同场宣读；两位作者都未出席，华莱士也未参与商定办法。
- 反响：论文发表初期反响冷淡；1859年《物种起源》引起轰动，首印1250册已被书商全部订购。
- 认可：华莱士1858年10月事后致信认可安排；1889年又以《达尔文主义》阐述自然选择，未用自己名字命名理论。